International Teacher Education

Written Motivation

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Written Motivation: Justifying Pedagogical and Content Choices

The designed lesson, *"Crises Across Centuries: Black Death vs. COVID-19,"* uses an inquiry-based framework to engage Grade 7 international students (12-year-olds) in historical and scientific analysis (OER Project, n.d.). The curriculum is framed around the **Big History Project (BHP)** (Threshold 7: Networks and Trade), which integrates history, biology, geography, and economics to examine human history through interconnected global systems (Christian et al., 2014). Grounded in BHP methodology, the lesson is structured around student inquiry in **scale switching**, moving dynamically between micro-level household experiences and macro-level global networks (Christian et al., 2014).

To support 12-year-old learners, especially English as an Additional Language (EAL) students, the worksheet avoids dense text passages. Instead, grounded in **Constructivist learning theory** (Vygotsky, 1978), it uses a clear three-step diagram (*Animal Host -> Vector -> Human*) alongside a dedicated Word Bank defining *"Vector"* in accessible language. This multimodal approach expands students' vocabulary while enabling them to link the 1347 Black Death directly to their own lived experiences of the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic, such as household lockdowns, face masks, and news coverage of global virus spread.

The lesson explicitly puts the **IB MYP Curriculum Framework** in action through the **Statement of Inquiry**: *"Human connectivity accelerates the spread of systemic shocks, yet while environments and technology evolve, core human behaviors remain constant through time"* (International Baccalaureate Organization [IBO], 2014). This is structured using the **GRASPs** model:

- **Goal & Role:** Students act like investigative claim testers evaluating historical continuity (IBO, 2014).
- **Audience & Situation:** Grade 7 peers analyzing historical parallels between medieval and modern pandemics.
- **Product:** A comparative matrix, vector transmission diagram, claim-testing analysis, and summative exit ticket.

These activities intentionally build **Approaches to Learning (ATL) Skills**, focusing on *Thinking Skills* (critical evaluation of claims) and *Communication/Media Literacy* (interpreting visual diagrams and articulating historical patterns) (IBO, 2014).

Finally, the lesson layout follows the **Design-Based Education (DBE)** cycle (NHL Stenden, 2021). It starts with a real-world driving question (*"Does history repeat itself?"*), progresses through research and comparative matrix prototyping, and applies learning via claim testing. Rather than viewing the Black Death and COVID-19 as isolated medical crises, scale

switching and network analysis help MYP students recognize them as recurring systemic adjustments in human network connectivity.

References (APA 7th Edition)

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